Small Mercies

By Cora Sorenson

INTRODUCTION

It got to a stage where I didn't know what the truth was and what was a lie. (Beat) I told him to stop, but he wouldn't. (Beat) I pushed him away, but he pushed me back. (Beat) I looked in the eyes of my children and know that they watched every bit. I changed. (Beat) I began to believe that it was my fault; like I was on this rollercoaster and I couldn't get off. (Long beat) But, we had our good times . .

Domestic violence is one of the hardest situations a person can go through. You love your other half so much that you excuse his behavior when you shouldn't. No one deserves to be abused, and no one should stay with an abuser, but sometimes it's not so easy to just walk away. The time is the early 1940s . . . things were different then. Josephine Smythe explains how she was always taught to be thankful for

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JOSEPHINE: The secret to happiness? To whose happiness? Yours? Mine? I can't claim to be an expert on anyone else's life but mine. When you've lived to 85, you've earned the right to call it a history, I think.

Routine. Expecting the expected. There is a comfort in that. Peace, I suppose. I like knowing what to expect. Surprises are . . . disquieting.

I was married on May Day, 1935. I had a beautiful white dress and there were so many wonderful flowers. My mother told me that I was the most glorious bride that she had ever seen. And I knew that I was marrying the handsomest man on earth. These film stars that all the young girls go all goofy over these days? Those men couldn't shake a stick compared to my Robert. He held my hand and told me that he would protect me, that he loved me. Oh, and how I loved him. My whole heart was filled up with that love and on that day, I was complete. I was everything I had ever dreamed of being. And he did, he treated me like I was his everything. We lived on the west coast then, and we would go out dancing. We loved jazz music, and he would turn me on the dance floor, and I would close my eyes and let myself fall

into him during those minutes. Those trumpets and trombones and clarinets were all playing for me. And he held me, my Robert. It's very difficult to articulate a love quite like that. A love that . . .

And oh, of course I had my dreams. I thought maybe I could be a nurse or a teacher or even an air hostess, but, you see, I had committed to him, and I agreed to stand behind my word. Because my word was what I had, you see? We wanted, more than anything, to start a family. We were blessed with a beautiful baby girl. Clara passed two weeks after she was born. Her heart was not fully developed. It was . . . damaged. She was so precious. Born with a full head of beautiful, thick hair. I had long dark hair when I was younger. And Robert and I would go walking through the gardens in the city, and he knew the scientific names of all of the flowers, and he knew how much I loved the flowers. And we walk through the roses and the gardenias and the rhododendrons and it was like we were dancing again, I could almost hear the piano and the . . .

I just need a small drink of water. I was injured while carrying Clara. I fell, but. . . I went . . . Forgetting would be a small mercy, perhaps. But, then, we are not to forget the things that brought us to our place today, now are we? Any of them? I suppose I might simply say it. Let me tell you, I've tried so many times to remember what it was that I had disagreed with Robert about that evening. It was in the summer, and I was several months along with Clara. I don't remember what it was, or I can't, or that part of my brain refuses to. I told him, "No," about something, and he struck me so hard in the stomach that I fell backwards down our staircase.

I do remember the thump-thump-thump of my body as I went down the stairs, like percussion, like this was some sort of dance gone wrong. And I remember, I felt like the spirit had been struck clean out of me. That was what hurt the most of anything that I could possibly imagine. And so there was a bit of a haze for a few moments there, sort of. . . sprawled out at the bottom of the stairs, and I went very quickly to a. . . a very different place altogether, a place where Robert and I were dancing in the middle of a very big garden and he was holding me so close, the life I wanted. The life I had expected to have. But I did

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not get to stay in that place. I looked up and Robert's face was there, above me, but it was not the face I knew. I did not know that he could be that ugly. And I closed my eyes until he made me get up. To see if I was bleeding.

What is the secret to happiness? I could have lost Clara that night, but something much bigger than me made certain that I was able to hold my little girl. That I was able to hold her for 13 days and 7 hours. . . Hold her and sing to her, "Hush little baby, don't you cry..." There are small mercies in this life.

How does one continue to love another at their own expense? I do not know the answer. I know that there were still small moments. Spaces of reprieve, I believe you could call them. Moments in time where I still saw the Robert that I had married, the man I had committed my life to. I did not know how to betray that commitment, and I did not know what had changed in him. It is very important to me that you understand that. And how I needed to believe that it was some failing, some sort of short-coming on my part. I tried to make everything just so. But there is no perfection that is flawless enough to overcome that kind of rage. A wrinkled shirt. A cup of coffee turned cold. A spot on the counter. All insignificant in their own regards and each one enough to inspire vengeance. To bring about the ugliness. His exaggerated consequences for my misdeeds. Broken wrists, arms, toes, ribs. He kicked me until I couldn't breathe. He split my lips so badly I feared that they would never heal. I always went back to the garden, dancing, dancing . . . How does a woman forsake her dignity in such a fashion?

I brought two handsome boys into the world. Beautiful, strong, healthy boys. And I protected them. It becomes easier to. . . endure when you have young babies sleeping in the next room over. I would have given everything I had to protect them and keep them safe. It is never enough.

Robert left for the war in 1941. I had dreams of leaving with the boys and going somewhere so far away. I thought perhaps I really could become an air hostess and that, somehow I could take the boys with me on the flights, and I would use expensive face powder and lip stain to

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cover up the bruises, and I would roll the cart down the narrow little aisle and turn to see my boys, strapped into their booster seats, waving at their Mama. Proud of their Mama. Now these really are the rants of an old lady.

Robert wrote me letters while he was away. He was very regular about that. Very routine. And they were wonderful letters.

Dearest Josie,

I do not know that I could live a single day without you. Protect yourself until I can return home . . . Robert.

Protect myself? Protect myself? I had to protect myself from you, Robert. I had to believe that I would not be killed at the hand of the man I loved. I had grown terrified you see, of the simplest things, the most everyday, commonplace things. Lit cigarettes as instruments of rage. Anything heavy that could be thrown. To bruise. To hurt. To make bleed. The inside of me was bleeding. I loved him so much and yet I felt so useless. So small. The safest I ever was was when you were away. I wanted so badly to pretend that he had changed. That he would return home as the man I married. (Beat)

It was such a cold day for September. The boys were not home from school yet and a man wearing a uniform arrived at our door. "Ma'am, are you Mrs. Robert Smythe?" And I recall that it was so impersonal. So directly to the point, "The United States Army regrets to inform you that your husband, Sergeant Robert P. Smythe lost his life while serving."

I do not precisely know how many emotions can stand together in a single moment. I know that I lied down on the floor of our bedroom, and I wept. I wept for the years that would not be returned to me. For broken bones and parts of my body that had long since healed and the soul that never would. I wept for Clara and the boys. And most of all I wept because I was happy that my husband would not be coming home. And, because of that, in mind, we could dance forever in the garden, while the band played on and on . . .

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AWARD HISTORY

2014 National Qualifier
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